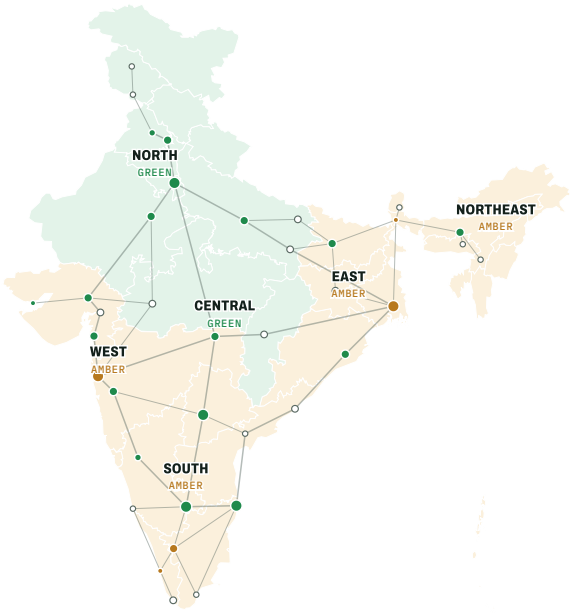
INB INDIA NETWORK BULLETIN · EDITION 019 SUNDAY 25 OCTOBER 2026 · 09:00 IST

Festive phone shipments fall 20%, and a cyclone nears Andhra

● NETWORK: AMBER

The festive sale's phone boxes are thinner this year: brands shipped 20% fewer phones in July to September and held back shop stock, Counterpoint says[1]. IMD now expects a very severe cyclone to cross the Andhra coast between Bapatla and Visakhapatnam by Wednesday noon[2]. Two states shut quick commerce warehouses over food safety this week, one in Bhiwandi[3].

HOW'S EACH REGION HOLDING UP?



Map: DataMeet, CC BY 4.0

DATES TO WATCH

● 25–26 Oct	Kerala red alerts, north and hill districts
● 25–27 Oct	Nilgiris ghat roads shut 6 pm to 6 am
● 25 Oct–7 Nov	NH-85 Adimali–Munnar shut at Second Mile
● Mon 26 Oct	Karnataka cane price meeting in Belagavi
● 26–27 Oct	Kolkata immersion bans, last round
● 26 Oct–5 Nov	NH-10 night closures
● Tue 27 Oct	Karnataka bandh threatened by cane farmers
● Wed 28 Oct	Very severe cyclone crosses the Andhra coast
● Sun 1 Nov	Delhi keeps out non-BS-VI vehicles from outside
● Sun 1 Nov	CMA CGM's new North Europe–India rates
● Sun 1 Nov	Ethanol year starts without sugar-based ethanol

● GREEN the sale season as usual, which can still be busy
● AMBER something beyond the season is slowing freight
● RED something is stopping freight across a state or a route

North

● GREEN

No delay beyond the season into Delhi, Lucknow or Amritsar.

West

● AMBER

JNPA's yard filled to 65% on Saturday from 60%, and import boxes waiting for inland trains rose again, to 3,380 TEU from 3,087[4,5]. The freight-station pile grew to 13,700 TEU. I'd expect Nhava Sheva's inland boxes to reach the Delhi, Nagpur and Ludhiana depots a day late until Wednesday.

South

● AMBER

Kerala has red alerts on Malappuram, Kozhikode and Wayanad today and on Idukki and Palakkad on Monday, and its disaster authority asks people to avoid night travel to the hills[6]. Cane farmers threaten a Karnataka bandh on Tuesday unless Monday's meeting with the Chief Minister in Belagavi answers their price demands, ANI reports[7,8]. I'd expect Kerala's hill loads to move by day only till Tuesday, and a bandh, if called, to hold Bengaluru's outbound trucks for the day and push Mysuru and Hubballi deliveries to Wednesday.

East

● AMBER

Petrapole's trade with Bangladesh restarted on Saturday morning after eight days shut, with 35 trucks crossing in the first hour against a usual 500-plus truckloads a day[9]. Monday and Tuesday nights bring Kolkata's final immersion curbs, two weeks into the Puja plan[10]. I'd expect the Bangladesh lorries backed up at Petrapole to be across by Wednesday, and Kolkata's deliveries back on time from Thursday.

Northeast

● AMBER

NH-10's night closures for slope work return on Monday and run to 5 November[11]. I'd expect Sikkim trucks that miss the evening cut-off at Siliguri to wait till morning, adding a day to Gangtok deliveries through the first week of November.

Central

● GREEN

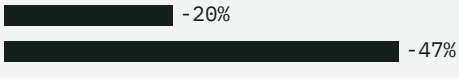
Nagpur, Indore and Raipur: no delay beyond the season.

NETWORK INSIGHTS

1 Phone shipments fall 20% before the sale, and cheap phones by almost half

MEDIUM CONFIDENCE

Fall in phone shipments, July–September 2026 against a year earlier (Counterpoint)



Brands shipped 20% fewer phones in July to September than a year earlier, a decade low, and held back shop stock even ahead of the festive season, Counterpoint says[1]. Phones under ₹20,000 fell 47%, as memory prices pushed models into higher price bands. So who is buying? Clothes: 72% of buyers in LocalCircles' survey of 67,000 urban shoppers plan them, and only 22% a phone[12]. The carriers' helplines are quiet too: searches for Ekart's customer care fell from 34 to 23 between Wednesday and Saturday[13]. I'd expect the fortnight before Diwali to carry more clothing parcels and fewer phone parcels than last year, filling vans by volume before revenue.

> **Brands selling online in apparel carry the Diwali fortnight, while phone brands and their sellers hold less stock to clear before 8 November. Carriers and 3PLs paid per shipment get more boxes of lower value, so van space runs out before revenue rises.**

2 IMD now expects a very severe cyclone on the Andhra coast by Wednesday noon

MEDIUM CONFIDENCE

IMD now expects a very severe cyclonic storm, winds 115 to 125 kmph, to cross the Andhra coast by Wednesday noon, enough to stop its ports and highway for a day[2]. The Hindu puts the landfall between Bapatla and Visakhapatnam. It builds in steps, Sambad English reports from the same bulletin: a cyclonic storm by Monday morning, a severe one by Tuesday morning, very severe near the coast[14]. Odisha has cancelled its Collectors' leave and shut schools in five southern districts on the 28th and 29th[14]. Andhra has red alerts on 13 districts for Tuesday and Wednesday, Kakinada, East Godavari and Krishna among them. Where does that leave freight? Visakhapatnam, Kakinada and Machilipatnam all sit inside the landfall stretch, and NH-16 runs along all of it. I'd expect those ports to stop working ships from Tuesday evening to Thursday, and NH-16 trucks between Vijayawada and Visakhapatnam to stand for most of Wednesday. Hyderabad's loads from the coast would then arrive a day late, on Friday.

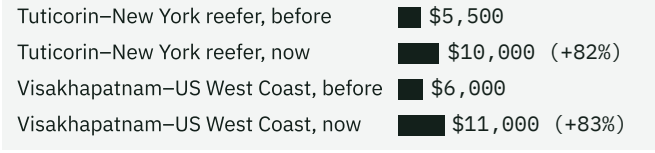
> **Manufacturers and exporters with cargo booked through Visakhapatnam, Gangavaram or Kakinada this week risk a rolled vessel, a week's wait for the next sailing and port storage costs. Online brands' Diwali stock going from Chennai to Kolkata by road sits out Wednesday on the coast, and carriers pay drivers to wait.**

3 Coimbatore's exporters pay nearly $10,000 to ship a reefer to New York, from $5,500

Kongu region's factories → Tuticorin and Visakhapatnam → the US

AMBER · HIGH COST OF DELAY · MEDIUM CONFIDENCE

Freight for a 40-foot box to the US, before and now, as exporters told The Times of India



A 40-foot refrigerated box from Tuticorin to New York now costs nearly $10,000 against about $5,500 before, Coimbatore's exporters told The Times of India[15]. Visakhapatnam to the US West Coast has gone from $6,000 to $11,000, they say. Why? The West Asia crisis means longer sailings, short containers and higher war-risk insurance, they say. Pump makers put their freight at three times its old rate, with transit times nobody can promise, and warn of cancelled orders[15]. Honestly, the bit that worries me is the timing: Visakhapatnam is also where Wednesday's cyclone comes ashore. I'd expect Tuticorin's reefer cargo and Coimbatore's engineering exports to ship less through November, and any box rolled at Visakhapatnam this week to wait another week for space.

> **Manufacturers and exporters in Tamil Nadu's engineering and food belts pay for every late sailing twice, in freight and in buyer patience. Carriers and 3PLs moving their boxes to Tuticorin wait longer for empty containers, so truck turns at the port slow.**

4 Two states shut quick commerce warehouses over food safety in one week

MEDIUM CONFIDENCE

Maharashtra's food regulator suspended the licence of a Blinkit warehouse in Bhiwandi and ordered all work there to stop, after finding 18,405 expired or spoiled items, Urban Acres reports[3]. In Uttar Pradesh, inspectors suspended four store licences, a Zepto warehouse in Ghaziabad among them, after 149 visits to e-commerce warehouses and dark stores, and say the drive goes on district by district[16]. Is this about hygiene or freight? Both. A warehouse with no licence ships nothing, and its orders move to the next store over, two weeks before Diwali. I'd expect more checks in other states before 8 November, and each sealed store to push a day's orders onto its neighbours.

> **Quick commerce platforms carry a new risk into their busiest fortnight: a store shut by an inspector, not by demand. Brands selling food and sweets through them may see orders held where a store is sealed, and carriers and 3PLs serving dark stores face sudden reroutes to the next one.**

THE LANES I'M WATCHING

NH-181 Mettupalayam–Coonoor ghat

● AMBER

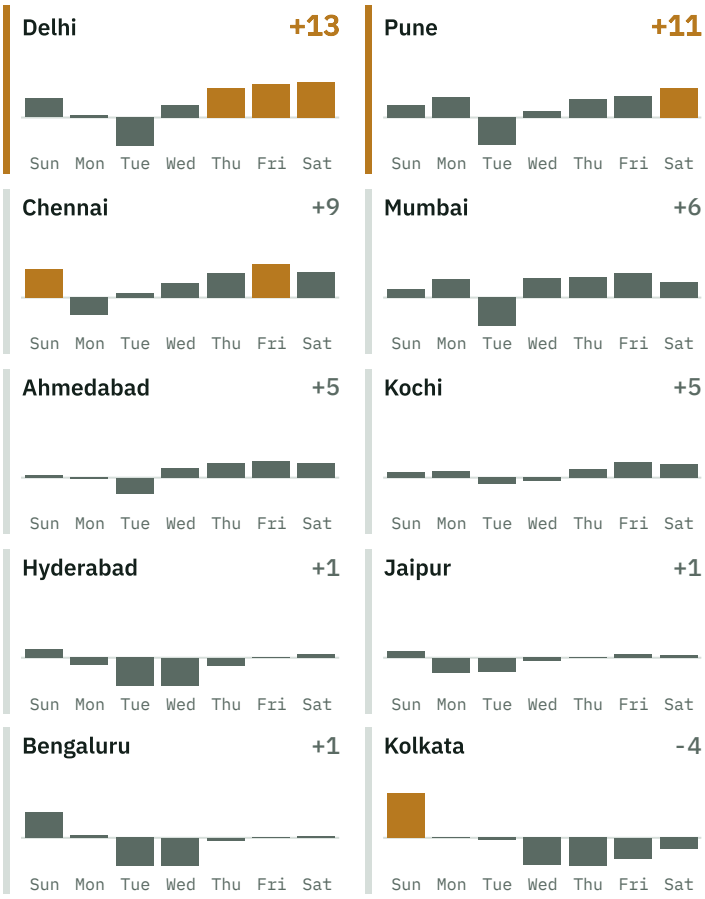
SHUT AT NIGHT AFTER LANDSLIDES

Landslides at more than 19 places buried a bus on Friday night, and the Coonoor and Kotagiri ghat roads are shut from 6 pm to 6 am for three days[17,18]. I'd expect Ooty's vegetable and tea loads to move by day only until Tuesday, half a day late into Coimbatore.

CITY TRAFFIC UPDATES

City roads against usual, daily, 18–24 Oct[19] amber = 10+ over

Delhi's lift from Thursday came with an Old RTR flyover carriageway shut until the 25th[20]. Chennai ran high on Friday through the rain[21]. Kolkata's lift last Sunday came under the Puja road closures[10].



HOW MY CALLS HAVE DONE

Of the 5 calls scored so far, 4 came true, 1 partly and none was wrong. 4 are still open. From 12 Oct:

1. The state retailers hold diesel prices through 19th October, while Jio-bp's and Nayara's stay ₹3 a litre higher. **Right.** No change reported at the state pumps; Nayara and Jio-bp charge ₹3 more. Source
2. Delhi's BS-IV exemption has not been extended by 19th October. **Right.** Gurugram police confirmed the 1 November cut-off on the 16th. Source

HOW THIS IS MADE

At 7 every morning, Claude drafts this page on its own using data available from public sources only. It reads the morning's public signals: city traffic in ten cities, the JNPA and Paradip port reports, ship queues at the container ports, toll-plaza truck counts, the seasonal calendar and about twenty news searches.

Then it writes, and a set of checks decides whether the draft is even fit for me to read. Every claim has to be opened and cited, and no source can be over a week old without a reason. No story from the last seven days comes back unless it actually moved, and nothing gets said twice.

I read it, argue with it, fix what's wrong and approve it. The ratings are my judgement on the likelihood of on-time delivery or cost-impact, not measured service levels or actual cost estimates. Confidence is High when the facts are dated and primary or measured, Medium when they rest on a proxy or a forecast. Does that make the page right? Not always, which is why the calls get scored.

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SOURCES

1. Free Press Journal: smartphone shipments fall 20%, Counterpoint, 23 Oct
2. The Hindu: Andhra braces for very severe cyclonic storm, 25 Oct
3. Urban Acres: Blinkit Bhiwandi warehouse licence suspended over expired stock, 24 Oct
4. JNPA daily status report, 24 Oct
5. JNPA daily status report, 23 Oct
6. India Today (PTI): Kerala red alert in five districts, 24 Oct
7. The News Mill (ANI): Karnataka cane farmers threaten bandh, 24 Oct
8. The Times of India: CM's cane price meeting on 26 Oct, 23 Oct
9. Free Press Journal: India–Bangladesh trade resumes at Benapole after eight-day Puja break, 24 Oct
10. Millennium Post: Kolkata Puja traffic plan, 5 Oct
11. ThePrint (PTI): NH-10 night curbs, 5 Oct
12. Storyboard18: urban India's festive spending likely to fall 6%, LocalCircles survey, 23 Oct
13. Google Trends: searches for carriers' customer care in India, 21–24 Oct
14. Sambad English: Cyclone Arnab, depression forms, 24 Oct
15. The Times of India: West Asia crisis hits Kongu exports, 24 Oct
16. India Today: UP suspends four food store licences, 24 Oct
17. The Times of India: bus buried by landslide on Coonoor ghat road, 24 Oct
18. Onmanorama: Nilgiris landslides strand hundreds, 24 Oct
19. TomTom Traffic Index, ten cities
20. The Pioneer: Old RTR flyover carriageway towards Vasant Vihar closed until 25 Oct, 22 Oct
21. The Week: Chennai heavy rain forecast till 27 October, schools shut, 23 Oct